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with a big daddy to obtain adam from little sister, your character could use regular combat means (guns). Of course big daddies can take all you've got and then some... After taking a pounding, the character decides to use some Splicer Irritant, a foul-smelling chemical produced courtesy your genetic enhancements. As the name suggests, this substance causes Splicers to go crazy and attack it. Splicers are genetically-mutated humans that constantly alter their genetic structures, and they're hostile.

Your character throws the Splicer Irritant on Big Daddy—Splicer jumps in to attack. You happen to cross a security camera while taking potshots at Big Daddy, and a mess of security bots spill out of nowhere to take you out. You run to the nearest security console, and using adam and your genetic enhancements program, set the bots to attack Big Daddy. You then shoot a propane tank and using telekinesis and Jedi Mind Trick powers, and divert this flow of propane on to Big daddy and then use a genetically-produced fireball to incinerate him, all the while pumping lead into him. Finally the beast goes down. The best part is the totally interactive environment means the next time you could do something totally different for the same result. If you had not gotten close to Little Sister, the above events wouldn't have happened. This makes *BioShock* totally autonomous—characters in the game world don't revolve around you, they're living their own life, doing their own thing!

*Time Shift*, due this Christmas, is a first person shooter with one twist—it allows you to fiddle with time. Imagine yourself pinned by enemy fire from atop a roof. You shoot at the walls behind which the enemy is hiding, causing a chunk of concrete to fall off the roof (the environment's destructible). You now sprint to this fallen chunk, climb on to it, and reverse time: voila, you're atop the roof as the chunk travels back up (reverse time) with you on it. This kind of gameplay is an evolution, made possible mainly due to advancements in allied technologies.

The biggest thing these past two years has undoubtedly been MMORPGs (Massively Multiplayer Online Role Playing Games). Although this (rather large) name is synonymous with *World of Warcraft* to many, they are many other MMORPGs floating around—*Guild Wars*, *Lord of the Rings Online*, *Everquest 2*, and *Eve Online*, to name a few.

Thousands of players from all over the world control game characters that populate these

vast game worlds. These types of games are more involving for some as you play with and against other human opponents instead of an AI system. The actual attraction of such role playing games is that they allow an alternative space (the virtual online space) to develop relationships. Consider this—many online games allow players to get friendly, purchase property, manage finances, and even get married and raise children. Divorce is also a possibility! Go to office, hang out at your favourite pub, and play golf on weekends... These games are giving gamers the world over an opportunity to escape from reality and live life the way they always wanted to, but never dared.

Another attraction of multiplayer online games is the community it creates. Most communities these days are a very close-knit bunch, living and breathing the game titles that created them. For example, *World of Warcraft* has communities of players that synchronise time around the world so that they can logon to the game and play at the same time. Die-hard fans of a particular game often create their own communities which have a strong online presence (homepages, concept art, gameplay tips, scores, member information, and fan kits, among others).

There are offline games for those who don't have fast connections, and for the working class who doesn't get a regular period every day to login and play. *The Sims* would be a good example. However, offline games are a trend that seems to be on the decline, and statistics show that 62 per cent of gamers worldwide prefer to game online rather than offline. In India this number is still low mainly due to poor penetration of both games and broadband.

Whether online or offline, whether single player or multiplayer—gaming has taken off and become a favourite pastime for people of all ages. As any pastime matures, a person looks for more involvement with it, to go a level deeper so as to further hold his or her interest. If this doesn't happen, one finds a new pastime. Thankfully there's a multi-billion dollar gaming industry coupled with an even more resourceful hardware industry that are working hard to ensure that day is postponed infinitely.

Games have moved from a pastime and become a way of life to many, and a means of living to some (read professional gamers). DirectX 10 and Vista will just be one of the scenes we visit on our journey. ☐

